# 3.1 The Middle Colonies

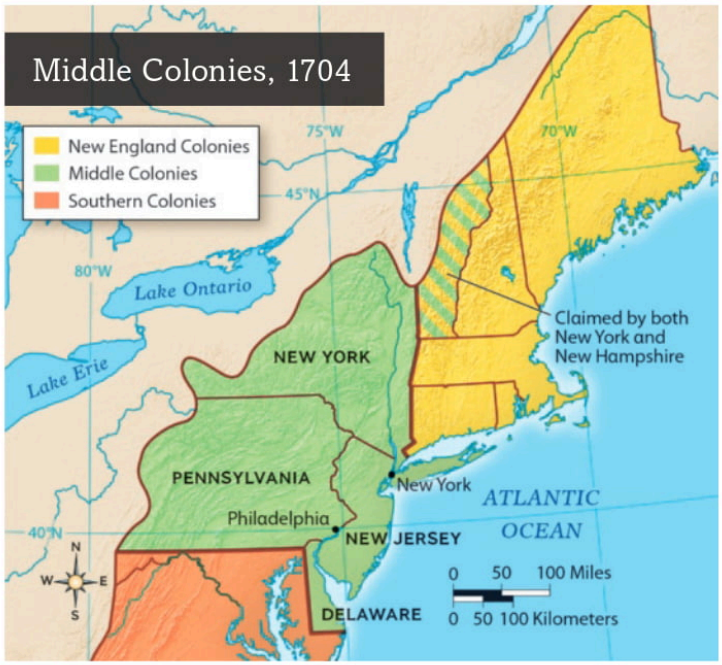
Have you ever traveled to a new place and discovered a culture different from that of your hometown? A colonist traveling south from New England to the Middle Colonies would meet people from European countries who were forging a unique colonial identity.

**MAIN IDEA** The Middle Colonies included a diverse mix of cultures and religions as people from different countries began to settle in the region.

## NEW NETHERLAND TO NEW YORK

Situated in the mid-Atlantic region of North America, the **Middle Colonies** included New York, New Jersey, Pennsylvania, and Delaware. Settlers from countries such as England, France, the Netherlands, Germany, Sweden, and Portugal came to the colonies for different reasons. Some were fleeing religious wars in their home countries. Others were conducting trade.

The first Dutch settlers arrived about 1614 and began trading with Native Americans. In 1624, Cornelius Jacobsen May, working on behalf of the Dutch West India Company, founded New Netherland to provide a base for trade in the Hudson River region. The first settlers of New Netherland worked for the company.




For about 15 years, colonists maintained good relations with Native Americans. However, disputes over land ownership grew. In particular, Native Americans objected to the Dutch settling on lands without a clear agreement that they could do so. Eventually, wars broke out.

In 1664, King Charles II of England gave his brother James, the duke of York, permission to force the Dutch out. The overwhelming English presence in the area made doing so easy and ensured the English complete control of eastern North America. James took over the colony and renamed it New York, and the English made peace with Native Americans living there.

## PENN'S WOODS

After assuming control of New York, James granted land between the Delaware and lower Hudson rivers to Lord John Berkeley and Sir George Carteret, who named the area New Jersey. New Jersey eventually split into West Jersey and East Jersey.

In 1681, Charles II granted a charter for a colony to an Englishman named **William Penn**. Penn wanted to establish a safe home for his fellow **Quakers**—members of the Religious Society of Friends, a Christian movement devoted to peaceful principles. Quakers emphasized education and equality and rejected formal worship and ministry. Because they were perceived by others as



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**CRITICAL VIEWING** In 1682, William Penn met with leaders of the Lenni Lenape under an elm tree on the Delaware River in present-day Philadelphia. There they signed a treaty promising cooperation. In this frieze, or sculpted panel, from the U.S. Capitol Rotunda, Penn is in the center, gesturing toward the activity around the chest. What details in this frieze reveal the reactions of the participants to the treaty signing?



anti-authority and even dangerous, thousands of Quakers were persecuted in England and even in the American colonies. Penn named his colony Sylvania, which means "woods." Charles II renamed it Pennsylvania, after Penn's father.

Penn set out to create a colony based on the Quaker **doctrine**—a principle or policy accepted by a group—that all are equal in the eyes of God. By applying this doctrine, he made Pennsylvania into an extremely diverse society, partly by encouraging religious minorities to settle there. Quaker doctrine also emphasized tolerance for others. In Pennsylvania, all colonists, no matter their religion, could worship in their own way.

Penn encouraged diversity in other ways, too. He kept peace with Native Americans, such as the Lenni Lenape. He purchased land from them, which he then sold to a variety of buyers—people from other colonies, different countries in Europe, and the West Indies. The Swedes, Finns, and Dutch who already inhabited the area became English subjects under Penn.

European settlers who lived in the "Lower Counties" in the southern part of the colony did not like living under Penn's government and at times clashed with Pennsylvania's authority. Penn tried unsuccessfully to unite the English and the Europeans, but in 1704, after two decades of difficulties, he allowed Delaware to form its own assembly. Elsewhere, and following Penn's death, conflicts between Native Americans and colonists continued.

## HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What factors contributed to the diversity of the Middle Colonies?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What caused William Penn to allow Delaware to form its own assembly?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Locate Delaware on the map. Why does it make sense that Penn might have difficulty uniting people who settled there with the settlers who lived in the rest of Pennsylvania?



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